

Foreword

We are now becoming familiar with the Internet, and the fantastic wealth of information of every sort we can access — and from everywhere in the world; literally millions of sites are just a click away, opening up new opportunities for trade.

Much of the use of the Internet has been to access information, and there's certainly lots of it. Currently over 625 terabytes of information, roughly the equivalent of 3 million sets of Encyclopaedia Britannicas, are accessed through the Internet each month. This traffic is increasing by more than 35% a month.

However, what was a novelty a very few years ago has now become commonplace technology. This has been a true revolution — the first Internet revolution; but now we are seeing the second Internet revolution — eCommerce.

The tools and techniques to enable trading over the Internet are now becoming mature, and eCommerce is growing very rapidly. Back in 1997 the global eCommerce market was estimated at \$10bn, but is predicted to rise to \$200—300bn, by 2002. This represents an increase of at least twentyfold. Over the same period, the global multimedia market, being more mature, will 'merely' quadruple, from \$150bn to \$600bn.

It is estimated that 25% of business revenues will be derived from the Internet by 2003.

BT has been at the forefront of research into eCommerce for a number of years, and has carried out much pioneering work in such areas as payments, trading and trust. There is a wealth of expertise in these fields at BT Laboratories — and the commercial drive in BT Products and Solutions is bringing these capabilities to market.

The papers in this eCommerce themed edition have been specially selected to give both a general overview of the subject and some detail of the technologies behind it.

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